How to Read This Book

The anatomy of a chapter

All 248 topic chapters follow the same eleven sections, which fall into three movements. Appendix A, in Volume 6, prints the template that every chapter was written against.

UNDERSTAND	1	**What it is**	A plain-English explanation, with every acronym defined on first use.
	2	**Why it matters**	What breaks, costs money, or wakes someone at 3 a.m. when this is misunderstood.
	3	**Real-world system**	How the topic shows up in a named, publicly documented system.
	4	**Diagram**	The real mechanism: a flow, a sequence, an architecture or a state machine.
	5	**How it works**	Key concepts, comparison tables and the commands that matter.
DO	6	**Step-by-step guide**	A lab you can type in a sandbox, with what to look for at each step.
	7	**Real-world scenario**	A short story under pressure: symptom, investigation, fix, lesson.
	8	**Mistakes and practices**	Two short lists: what not to do, and what to do.
PROVE	9	**Tasks**	Hands-on work, easiest first, each with a "done when" check. The last says Prove it.
	10	**Self-check**	Questions a senior engineer would expect you to answer without notes.
	11	**Further reading**	Official documentation and well-known books.

The eleven sections of every topic chapter

Each level opens with an overview of its goal, recommended time and topics, and closes with a **capstone project** marked with a star, which pulls all of that level's topics together.

Conventions used in print

- **Cross-references.** Where the repository has a hyperlink, this book prints a small tag after the words: Docker Compose §4.8 means Level 4, topic 8. Running heads carry the same numbers, so you can flip straight to it. In a PDF the tags are clickable when the target is in the same volume.
- **Check-boxes.** Every task has a box to tick with a pencil. Where the text mentions changing `- [ ]` to `- [x]`, that is the same idea for readers who keep their progress in a fork of the repository.

- **Answers.** On GitHub the self-check answers are folded away. In print they sit in a shaded box straight after the questions, so cover it with a card and answer first.
- **Code.** Long lines wrap, and the continuation is indented. Type a wrapped line as one line. Output is illustrative and yours may differ in the details.
- **Diagrams.** A few wide diagrams are printed sideways. Turn the book clockwise to read them.
- **Lab notes.** Chapters start on a right-hand page, and any left-hand page this leaves empty is ruled for your notes. Use them. For each task, write what you ran and what you saw. Explaining output is the skill.

Stay safe, and keep it cheap

Use disposable sandboxes: local virtual machines, Docker, kind or minikube, LocalStack, or a small VPS. Anything that can cost money says so and ends with teardown steps. Never practise on a system you cannot afford to lose.